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National Disaster Response Force, Roles, Structure, Operations

National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) is India's specialized disaster response agency under MHA, trained for rapid rescue, relief and CBRN emergencies nationwide.

By **Shakshi Kant** - Nov 1, 2025, 17:44 IST

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Disasters, whether natural or human-induced, pose major challenges to India's safety and development. To address these effectively, India established a specialized force capable of rapid deployment and professional disaster management. The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) stands at the forefront of India's emergency response system, ensuring quick, coordinated, and efficient rescue and relief operations across the country. Over the years, NDRF has evolved into one of the most trained and reliable disaster management forces in the world.

National Disaster Response Force

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The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) is a specialized, multi-skilled disaster response agency raised under the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). It was constituted under the Disaster Management Act, 2005, and the NDRF was formally raised and became operational in 2006 (raising day: 19 January 2006).

NDRF is administratively under the Ministry of Home Affairs; the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) issues policy/ guidelines and coordinates at the national level, but administrative control and raising of NDRF rests with MHA. Its motto, "Aapda Sewa Sadaiv Sarvatra" (To serve during disasters, always and everywhere), reflects its commitment to saving lives and minimizing suffering.

National Disaster Response Force Organizational Structure

The NDRF functions as an independent disaster response agency but draws its personnel from various central paramilitary forces. Its organizational framework ensures coordination between central and state disaster management authorities.

- Parent Ministry: Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA)
- Controlling Authority: National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA)
- Head: Director General (DG), NDRF
- Composition: Personnel deputed from BSF, CRPF, ITBP, CISF, and SSB

As of 2025, NDRF comprises 16 battalions strategically located across India to ensure rapid deployment. Each battalion includes 1149 personnel specializing in disaster response, search and rescue, communication, and medical assistance.

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National Disaster Response Force Roles and Responsibilities

The NDRF has a broad mandate that goes beyond immediate rescue operations. Its roles cover preparedness, response, mitigation, and capacity building.

- Disaster Response: Conducts search, rescue, and relief operations during natural calamities such as

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floods, cyclones, landslides, and earthquakes.

- CBRN Response: Trained to handle Chemical, Biological, Radiological, and Nuclear emergencies.
- Capacity Building: Provides disaster management training to State Disaster Response Forces (SDRFs) and community volunteers.
- Awareness Programs: Conducts public awareness campaigns on disaster preparedness.
- International Missions: Participates in humanitarian assistance operations abroad under UN coordination.

National Disaster Response Force Operations

The NDRF's operational efficiency lies in its rapid deployment strategy. Teams are pre-positioned in disaster-prone areas and mobilized immediately after early warnings from the India Meteorological Department (IMD) or National Centre for Seismology. Major Operations Conducted:

- 2008 Bihar Floods: Rescued over 1.3 lakh people from Kosi River floods.
- 2013 Uttarakhand Flash Floods: Conducted one of India's largest rescue missions, saving over 10,000 lives.
- 2018 Kerala Floods: Deployed 58 teams; rescued over 5,000 people and evacuated 10,000.
- 2020 Cyclone Amphan: Over 40 NDRF teams deployed across West Bengal and Odisha.
- 2023 Turkey-Syria Earthquake: India sent NDRF teams under "**Operation Dost**" for international rescue support, showcasing global capability.

National Disaster Response Force Training

Training is the backbone of NDRF's operational excellence. Personnel undergo rigorous physical, technical, and psychological training to handle extreme conditions. By 2024, more than lakhs of civilians and officials have received disaster response training under NDRF-led initiatives. **Key Training Institutions:**

- National Institute of Disaster Management (NIDM)- Delhi
- College of Disaster Management- Nagpur
- State Training Centers- located in all disaster-prone states

Training Focus Areas:

- Collapsed structure search and rescue (CSSR)
- Rope rescue, flood rescue, and underwater diving operations



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- Chemical and radiological decontamination
- First aid and trauma care
- Community-based disaster risk management

National Disaster Response Force Technological Advancements

To enhance operational efficiency, NDRF continuously upgrades its technology and equipment. In 2023, NDRF integrated drones for aerial surveillance and AI-based early warning systems, enabling faster and data-driven decision-making during rescue missions.

- Boats and Hovercrafts: Used for flood rescue operations.
- CBRN Vehicles and Drones: For chemical disasters and surveillance.
- Communication Equipment: Satellite phones and GPS-based tracking systems.
- Medical Kits and Protective Gear: Advanced equipment for first responders.

National Disaster Response Force Coordination

Disaster response requires multi-agency coordination. This collaboration ensures seamless integration from local preparedness to national-level coordination. NDRF collaborates closely with:

- National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) for strategic planning.
- Indian Armed Forces for logistics and airlifting operations.
- India Meteorological Department (IMD) for early warnings.
- National Remote Sensing Centre (NRSC) for satellite-based disaster mapping.
- State Disaster Response Forces (SDRFs) for localized operations.

National Disaster Response Force Legal Framework

The Disaster Management Act, 2005, provides the legal foundation for NDRF's creation and functioning. It outlines roles for NDMA, NDRF, SDRF, and other authorities in disaster risk reduction and response. Key legal provisions related to NDRF include:

- Section 44: Establishment of NDRF for prompt response.
- Section 45: Defines NDRF's control, training, and deployment framework.



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- Section 46: Establishment of the National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF) for financing operations.
- Additionally, NDMA guidelines ensure coordination between central, state, and district authorities.

National Disaster Response Force Funding

The NDRF receives financial support from the National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF) under the Ministry of Home Affairs.

- **Budget Allocation:** Public records indicate that the 15th Finance Commission allocated a total corpus of ₹54,770 crore to the National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF) for the entire award period of 2021-22 to 2025-26. An amount of ₹5,000 crore from this corpus was specifically earmarked for the Expansion and Modernization of Fire Services across the states..
- **World Bank Partnership:** Supports capacity building through the National Cyclone Risk Mitigation Project (NCRMP).
- **UNDP Collaboration:** Enhances community resilience and early warning systems.

National Disaster Response Force Achievements

NDRF has earned global recognition for its professionalism, speed, and compassion.

- Conducted over 6,800 rescue operations since inception.
- Assisted in international missions like the Nepal Earthquake (2015) and Turkey-Syria Earthquake (2023).
- Recognized by UNDRR (United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction) for community-based disaster management excellence.
- Awarded the **Subhash Chandra Bose** Aapda Prabandhan Puraskar 2023 for outstanding disaster response efforts.

National Disaster Response Force Challenges

Despite its success, NDRF faces several operational and institutional challenges.

1. Resource Constraints: Limited funds restrict modernization.
 - Way Forward: Increase budget allocation and public-private partnerships.
2. Coordination Issues: Overlapping jurisdiction with state forces.
 - Way Forward: Streamline command structures between NDRF and SDRF.



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3. Staff Shortage: High turnover due to deputation model.
 - Way Forward: Establish permanent cadre and incentivize long-term postings.
4. Technological Gaps: Limited access to advanced rescue tools.
 - Way Forward: Invest in AI, robotics, and GIS-based disaster mapping.
5. Climate-Induced Disasters: Rising frequency of floods and cyclones.
 - Way Forward: Develop predictive disaster models and preventive infrastructure.
6. Public Awareness: Low community preparedness.
 - Way Forward: Strengthen community-based disaster management training.
7. Training Infrastructure: Regional disparities in training standards.
 - Way Forward: Establish regional disaster training academies.
8. Post-Disaster Rehabilitation: Focus often ends after rescue.
 - Way Forward: Expand NDRF's role to include post-disaster livelihood recovery.
9. Equipment Maintenance: Short shelf life of rescue gear.
 - Way Forward: Regular audits and replacement cycles.
10. Mental Health of Personnel: Psychological toll after major disasters.
 - Way Forward: Provide counseling and stress management programs.

National Disaster Response Force International Operations

The NDRF has increasingly become a symbol of India's humanitarian diplomacy by taking part in global disaster relief efforts. In 2023, NDRF earned international acclaim for its swift response during the Turkey-Syria Earthquake under "Operation Dost," rescuing several survivors and providing medical aid. Earlier, NDRF teams had participated in the 2011 Japan Earthquake, 2015 Nepal Earthquake, and Bhutan flood response operations. These missions highlight India's commitment to the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction (2015-2030) and its growing leadership in global disaster response under the principle of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" – One Earth, One Family.

National Disaster Response Force Battalions

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) operates through 16 specialized battalions located across India, strategically placed based on the country's disaster vulnerability profile. These battalions are equipped to respond rapidly to floods, earthquakes, cyclones, industrial accidents, and other natural or man-made calamities. Each unit is drawn from different Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) and maintains a defined Area of Responsibility (AOR) for effective disaster response.



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National Disaster Response Force Area of Responsibility

These battalions work in coordination with State Disaster Response Forces (SDRFs) and the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) to ensure timely and effective response during calamities. Their strategic distribution enables faster mobilization, reducing response time significantly in high-risk zones. The deployment and area of responsibilities for the NDRF battalions is given here:

- **1st Battalion NDRF, Guwahati (Assam)- BSF:** Covers the North-Eastern states, focusing on floods, landslides, and earthquakes. It is one of the first responders for Brahmaputra basin disasters.
- **2nd Battalion NDRF, Nadia (West Bengal)- BSF:** Responsible for eastern India, including West Bengal and Sikkim, with emphasis on cyclones, riverine floods, and industrial accidents.
- **3rd Battalion NDRF, Cuttack (Odisha)- CISF:** Focuses on Odisha, Jharkhand, and Chhattisgarh, frequently responding to cyclones like Fani and Amphan, and mining-related disasters.
- **4th Battalion NDRF, Vellore (Tamil Nadu)- CISF:** Covers Tamil Nadu, Kerala, and Puducherry, addressing cyclones and coastal flooding in the Bay of Bengal and Arabian Sea regions.
- **5th Battalion NDRF, Pune (Maharashtra)- CRPF:** Handles Western India (Maharashtra, Goa, and Karnataka) with key roles in urban flood rescue and industrial response.
- **6th Battalion NDRF, Vadodara (Gujarat)- CRPF:** Focuses on Gujarat and Rajasthan, known for earthquake preparedness (Bhuj) and flood management.
- **7th Battalion NDRF, Bathinda (Punjab)- ITBP:** Responsible for Punjab, Haryana, and Himachal Pradesh, dealing with flash floods, landslides, and industrial hazards.
- **8th Battalion NDRF, Ghaziabad (Uttar Pradesh)- ITBP:** Covers Delhi NCR and Uttar Pradesh, frequently responding to building collapses, urban flooding, and accidents.
- **9th Battalion NDRF, Patna (Bihar)- BSF:** Focuses on Bihar and Jharkhand, handling recurrent floods in the Ganga basin and rescue during monsoon disasters.
- **10th Battalion NDRF, Vijayawada (Andhra Pradesh)- CRPF:** Covers Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, addressing cyclones from the Bay of Bengal and dam-related emergencies.
- **11th Battalion NDRF, Varanasi (Uttar Pradesh)- SSB:** Handles eastern UP and northern Madhya Pradesh, focusing on flood rescue and earthquake response.
- **12th Battalion NDRF, Itanagar (Arunachal Pradesh)- SSB:** Responsible for Arunachal Pradesh and nearby states, focusing on landslides, earthquakes, and mountain rescue operations.
- **13th Battalion NDRF, Samba (Jammu and Kashmir)- Assam Rifles:** Covers Jammu, Kashmir, and Ladakh, focusing on avalanches, landslides, and earthquake preparedness in Himalayan terrain.
- **14th Battalion NDRF, Mandi (Himachal Pradesh)- ITBP:** Deployed in Himachal Pradesh and northern regions, dealing with flash floods, landslides, and glacier bursts.



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- **15th Battalion NDRF, Haldwani (Uttarakhand)- ITBP:** Responsible for Uttarakhand and Western UP, with expertise in mountain search and rescue and flood operations.
- **16th Battalion NDRF, Najafgarh (New Delhi)- BSF:** Covers the National Capital Region and nearby states, handling chemical, biological, radiological, and nuclear (CBRN) emergencies, along with urban disasters.

NDRF

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) symbolizes India's commitment to saving lives and ensuring resilience against disasters. From responding to floods and cyclones to handling international emergencies, NDRF has built trust and credibility worldwide. Going forward, strengthening technology, capacity building, and coordination will make it not only India's shield during calamities but also a global model for effective disaster management.

National Disaster Response Force UPSC

In recent years, the National Disaster Response Force has expanded its operational strength and technological readiness. As of 2025, NDRF operates 16 battalions with enhanced logistical support and regional coordination. The force has introduced AI-based disaster prediction tools, drones for real-time surveillance, and satellite-linked communication systems for efficient data sharing. The NDRF has also increased its community outreach programs, training over 12 lakh citizens in disaster preparedness through mock drills and awareness campaigns nationwide.

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National Disaster Response Force FAQs

Q1. When was the National Disaster Response Force established?



Q2. How many National Disaster Response Force battalions are there in India?



Q3. Which ministry controls the National Disaster Response Force?



Q4. What types of disasters does the National Disaster Response Force handle?



Q5. What is the motto of the National Disaster Response Force?



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